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MEMORANDUM

TO: Local Government Unit of Bacolod, Lanao del Norte

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SUBJECT: Policy Recommendations for Optimizing Household Waste Segregation under RA 9003

Rationale and Background

Despite Municipal Ordinance No. 2018-05 and the national mandates of the Ecological Solid Waste Management Act (RA 9003), the rate of households actually separating their trash at home in Bacolod remains extremely low, currently estimated at only 10%.

Our research reveals that this low compliance is not simply because people are uneducated about the environment. Instead, the real problems are that segregating is currently too inconvenient, and the municipality's strict ₱1.5 million annual Solid Waste Management (SWM) budget is being spread too thin to make a real impact. To create lasting habits within this budget, a shift toward a data-driven, strategic approach is required.

Key Findings

- **The "Convenience Barrier":** The primary reason people do not segregate is simply that it is physically difficult or inconvenient, which accounts for 83% of the behavioral problem. When logistical friction is high (e.g., lack of accessible bins or collection support), it overrides a person's good intentions to help the environment..
- **The Value-Action Gap:** Standard Information, Education, and Communication (IEC) campaigns—like seminars and flyers—are no longer effective on their own. Residents already have high environmental awareness, but this knowledge does not translate into action when systemic barriers remain high.
- **Failure of the "Status Quo" Equal Distribution:** Currently, the limited SWM budget is divided evenly across all seven barangays. This "status quo" spreads the money so thin that it fails to fund enough enforcement or incentives to actually change behavior, causing compliance to stagnate—especially in densely populated areas like Barangay Poblacion.

Specific Policy Recommendations

A. Transition from "Equal Distribution" to a "Sequential Saturation" Strategy

- **The Concept:** Instead of spreading the budget thinly everywhere at once, focus heavily on one area at a time
- **Action:** Stop the equal distribution of the municipal SWM budget.
- **Implementation:** Concentrate 50% to 90% of the budget on just one or two targeted barangays to create an intense "Shock and Awe" period of strict enforcement and high rewards.
- **The Logic:** Keep this up until the barangay reaches a "Social Tipping Point" (around 70% compliance). At this point, peer pressure and social norms take over, and segregating becomes a community habit. The LGU can then reduce funding in that area to a low maintenance level and move the heavy funding to fix the next barangay.

B. Decouple Policy Instruments Based on Barangay Demographics

Different communities require completely different approaches:

- **For High-Density Urban Centers (e.g., Brgy. Poblacion):** These areas suffer from an "Urban Resource Trap," meaning populations are so large that people feel anonymous, making social pressure ineffective. Stop spending money on educational campaigns and small monetary rewards here. Instead, dedicate the budget strictly to high-visibility enforcement (like designated enforcers) to increase the perceived risk of getting caught.
- **For Smaller/Low-Income Communities (e.g., Brgy. Babalaya, Brgy. Demologan):** In smaller populations, monetary rewards or structural support are highly effective. Because there are fewer people, the reward amount per person remains meaningful and can successfully motivate the community without draining the budget.

C. Prioritize Friction Reduction Over Awareness Campaigns

- **Action:** Reallocate funds currently used for general environmental seminars toward initiatives that actually make segregation physically easier for households.
- **Implementation:** Invest in accessible infrastructure, better collection logistics, and structural support. Recognize that convenience dictates compliance far more than an individual's desire to be "green".

Conclusion

The challenge of solid waste management in Bacolod is a complex issue involving both human behavior and physical logistics. By abandoning the equal distribution model in favor of a targeted "Sequential Saturation" approach, and by customizing rewards and enforcements to fit the unique realities of each barangay, the LGU can maximize its budget. This strategy will trigger self-sustaining, pro-environmental habits that will keep Bacolod clean for the long term.